then put together a big partnership and the stage was set for Bhajji to have the final word on Australian soil. First he ran Hayden out, following a misunderstanding with Symonds, and then just two balls later Symonds missed a ball that turned a long way and was trapped lbw. Unsurprisingly, Bhajji enjoyed his wicket more than any other.

The match wasn't over yet, however, with James Hopes playing some aggressive strokes. In the end, Hopes was out last, for 63, but by picking up wickets regularly at the other end we had ensured that he was constantly under pressure. Nevertheless, the match was closer than expected and when the final wicket fell, Australia were only ten runs away from winning the game.

It was a great feeling to win, and seeing the tricolour being waved all over the Gabba was a terrific sight. We had beaten Australia in Australia and were also delighted to have proved Ricky Ponting right. He did not have to play a third final, just as he had predicted.

Grasping the nettle

My physical condition was deteriorating by the day. It didn't help that the problem still hadn't been diagnosed properly and I didn't know exactly what I was suffering from. In any case, there wasn't much time to do anything about it as the first of three home Tests against South Africa was due to start at Chennai a couple of weeks later, on 26 March 2008.

After getting as much rest as I could, I went to Chennai, and in the evening before the game had three injections in my groin. The doctors sounded confident that they would enable me to play the next day. When I got up the following morning the pain was substantially reduced, but John Gloster and I decided I should undertake a fitness test. I found I was able to run around during practice and also played our customary game of football without feeling too much discomfort. John declared me fit to play.

It was unlucky for me that South Africa won the toss and then batted for two long days as they compiled 540, with Amla making 159. Fielding in the heat quickly brought back the pain and when I finally batted on the fourth day I was so stiff and sore that I got out without scoring to Makhaya Ntini, caught by Kallis at second slip. At the end of the match,